CASH TO COMPANY · STRATEGIC REFERENCE

a FlexLifeFi K-12 program

Cash & Company

MASTER · ASSESSMENT TOOLKIT

Rubric Bank

Every formative and summative rubric used across the K-12 program.

Single-point and analytic rubrics - calibrated to grade-band outcomes - that teachers, students, and parents can read in one glance and use in one minute.

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Every formative and summative rubric used across the K-12 program.

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> Assessment that changes what the student does next - not just what the gradebook records.

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Five reusable analytic rubrics at a 4-point scale with specific descriptors. Each rubric maps to a recurring assessment type used across grade levels. Descriptors are observable, not vague — "uses two interview quotes," not "shows understanding."

Scale used in every rubric:

- **4 — Exemplary.** Exceeds proficiency; sophisticated, evidence-rich, generalizable beyond the assignment.
- **3 — Proficient.** Hits the target; meets the named outcome reliably.
- **2 — Developing.** Approaches target; partial evidence with named gaps.
- **1 — Beginning.** Significant misunderstanding or absent evidence.

Calibration norms:

- Each criterion is scored independently.
- Pull a 3 anchor paper before scoring; recalibrate to it.
- Read for evidence, not effort.
- Holistic scoring is allowed only on Cash-video reflections; Capstone checkpoints require analytic scoring.

The rubrics:

1. **Business Plan Rubric** — for any unit producing a written business plan (Grades 4–12, scaled).
2. **Pitch Presentation Rubric** — for live or recorded pitches (Grades 5–12, scaled).
3. **Budget Project Rubric** — for any unit producing a structured budget (Grades 4–12, scaled).
4. **Customer Research Rubric** — for any unit producing a persona or customer-evidence artifact (Grades 5–12, scaled).
5. **Reflection Writing Rubric** — for any unit producing a reflection journal or end-of-unit memo (Grades 3–12, scaled).

Each rubric includes a "scale notes" section telling teachers how to dial up/down complexity by grade band.

Rubric 1 — Business Plan Rubric

For: any assignment in which a student produces a written plan describing a business they would (or do) run. Used at Grades 4 (1-page plan), 6 (plan + RACI), 8 (plan + break-even), 10 (plan + structure), 12 (full Capstone plan).

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Criterion	4 — Exemplary	3 — Proficient	2 — Developing	1 — Beginning
Customer clarity	Names a specific customer with at least 2 behavioral details and a quote or observation supporting the choice; explains who the product is not for.	Names a specific customer with 1 behavioral detail and a reason; mostly demographic but one behavior named.	Names a customer category (e.g., "kids") without behavioral detail or supporting evidence.	No customer specified, or named in a way that contradicts the product.
Value proposition	Clearly states what the product/service does, for whom, and what specific frustration it addresses, supported by evidence; tradeoffs acknowledged.	States what the product does and the customer it serves; the connection is plausible.	States a product but the customer-need link is implied, not stated.	Product described without reference to a customer need.
Financial logic (band-appropriate)	Cost, price, contribution margin (or grade-appropriate equivalent) all computed; tested under at least 2 scenarios; sensible reasoning for chosen price.	Cost, price, and a profit number computed correctly; price defended with one reason.	Some math present; arithmetic errors or incomplete categories; price not connected to costs.	Numbers absent or wholly inconsistent.
Operations and roles	Clear plan for how the business runs, who does what, and how decisions are made; SOPs or RACI present where age-appropriate.	Roles named for the team; basic process described.	Roles named but vague; process implied rather than specified.	No operations described, or assumes "I'll figure it out."
Honest self-assessment	Identifies at least 2 risks or weak spots; describes what would have to be true for the plan to fail; proposes mitigations.	Names 1 risk and one way to address it.	Mentions concerns vaguely without specifics.	Plan written as if no risk exists.
Communication	Plan is concise, clear, well-organized; reader can grasp the business in under 3 minutes.	Plan is organized; minor friction in reader experience.	Plan is present but disorganized; reader has to work to extract the model.	Plan is hard to follow; key elements absent.

Scale notes by grade band:

- **Grades 4–5:** Drop "Operations and roles" and "Honest self-assessment" criteria; weight the rest equally. Replace "contribution margin" with "cost, revenue, profit." Total 4 criteria.
- **Grades 6–8:** Use all 6 criteria. "Financial logic" expects contribution margin (Grade 7) or break-even (Grade 8). "Operations" expects a SOP or RACI.
- **Grades 9–12:** Use all 6. "Financial logic" expects unit economics, COGS, gross margin minimum (Grade 9–10), and full P&L + cash flow at 11–12. "Operations" expects functional breakdown and dependencies.

Rubric 2 — Pitch Presentation Rubric

For: any live or recorded pitch — Grade 5 elevator pitch, Grade 8 messaging defense, Grade 11 investor-style pitch, Grade 12 Capstone defense.

Criterion	4 — Exemplary	3 — Proficient	2 — Developing	1 — Beginning
Customer + need clarity	In under 60 seconds, audience can repeat back exactly who the customer is and what frustration they have, with a specific detail.	Audience can name the customer category and the general need.	Audience can name only one of customer or need.	Audience cannot articulate either.
Evidence and specifics	At least 2 pieces of concrete evidence (quote, number, observation) cited; numbers are accurate; sources implied or named.	At least 1 concrete piece of evidence cited; mostly accurate.	Generalities ("a lot of people," "everyone") without specifics.	No evidence cited; reliance on personal opinion.
Logical flow	Pitch follows a clear arc (problem → customer → solution → evidence → ask) without repetition or detour; transitions are deliberate.	Pitch covers required elements; some transitions awkward but flow is followable.	Pitch covers some elements but skips one; flow has noticeable gaps.	Pitch is fragmented; major elements missing.
Q&A handling	Responds to all questions directly; cites evidence even under pressure; concedes uncertainty honestly when present.	Responds to most questions; one or two get vague answers.	Responds to questions but often pivots to comfort topics; misses what was asked.	Cannot or does not respond meaningfully to questions.

Criterion	4 — Exemplary	3 — Proficient	2 — Developing	1 — Beginning
Honest claims (ethics)	All claims are specific, verifiable, and free of manipulative framing; presenter passes the 4-point Fair-to-Customer Check unprompted.	Claims are specific; minor unverifiable language but no manipulation.	Some vague or hype-leaning claims; would not pass the Fair-to-Customer Check on review.	Manipulative or unverifiable claims central to the pitch.
Delivery	Eye contact, vocal pacing, and visual aids all serve the message; presenter is composed even with hard questions.	Generally clear delivery; minor pacing or visual issues.	Delivery hampers comprehension at points (rushed, monotone, slides cluttered).	Delivery seriously interferes with message.

Scale notes by grade band:

- **Grades 5–6 (30-sec to 60-sec pitch):** Drop "Q&A handling" criterion; weight remaining 5 equally. Replace "honest claims" with simpler "claims are specific (no 'everyone loves it')."
- **Grades 7–8 (2–3 min pitch):** Use all 6. Q&A is brief (1–2 questions).
- **Grades 9–12 (5+ min pitch):** Use all 6. Q&A is substantive (3–5 panel questions). At Grade 12, add a separate evidence-portfolio expectation in the Q&A criterion.

Rubric 3 — Budget Project Rubric

For: any structured budget assignment — Grade 4 event budget, Grade 6 monthly ledger, Grade 8 break-even calculator, Grade 11 cash flow forecast, Grade 12 startup financial pack.

Criterion	4 — Exemplary	3 — Proficient	2 — Developing	1 — Beginning
Mathematical accuracy	All calculations correct, including subtotals, totals, and percentages where applicable; formulas (in spreadsheet) are correct and reusable.	Calculations mostly correct; one minor arithmetic error that does not change the conclusion.	Multiple arithmetic errors; one or more change the conclusion.	Calculations significantly inaccurate or absent.
Realism of inputs	Income and expense estimates are realistic for the stated context; cited sources or analogs where applicable.	Estimates are plausible; one or two are guessed without justification.	Several estimates are unrealistic (too high or too low) and unjustified.	Estimates are arbitrary or magical (e.g., "$0 cost").

Criterion	4 — Exemplary	3 — Proficient	2 — Developing	1 — Beginning
Category completeness	All major categories present and at correct grain (no double-counting, no missing essentials).	Most major categories present; one minor category missing.	Important categories missing or muddled together.	Many essential categories absent.
Justification of choices	Every meaningful choice (price, savings rate, allocation) has a written reason rooted in the project context.	Most choices justified; some by default rather than reasoning.	Justifications are general ("seemed right") without context.	Choices unexplained.
Treatment of uncertainty	Includes at least 2 scenarios or a sensitivity check; identifies the input the result is most sensitive to.	Includes 1 scenario or notes one variable as uncertain.	Acknowledges uncertainty without modeling it.	No acknowledgment of uncertainty.
Communication	Budget is clearly labeled, well-organized, includes a brief written summary; a non-finance reader could understand it.	Budget is organized; minor friction for the reader.	Budget is present but requires interpretation.	Budget is hard to read or interpret.

Scale notes by grade band:

- **Grade 4:** Drop "Treatment of uncertainty" and "Justification of choices" criteria; replace "Communication" with simpler "Budget is neat and labeled." 4 criteria total.
- **Grades 5–8:** Use all 6 with adjusted complexity. "Treatment of uncertainty" at 6–8 means a single what-if scenario.
- **Grades 9–12:** Use all 6 at full complexity. Grade 12 expects three-statement consistency (P&L, cash flow, balance sheet sketch align).

Rubric 4 — Customer Research Rubric

For: any artifact based on customer evidence — Grade 4 1-sentence customer statement, Grade 6 segment description, Grade 7 Persona Pack, Grade 9 customer-discovery report, Grade 11 sales-conversation analysis.

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Criterion	4 — Exemplary	3 — Proficient	2 — Developing	1 — Beginning
Quality of evidence	At least 3 different sources of customer evidence (interviews, surveys, observations); specific quotes and counts cited; direct evidence over hearsay.	At least 2 sources; some specific evidence; mostly direct.	1 source; evidence is general; hearsay or assumption mixed in.	Customer evidence absent or fabricated.
Specificity of persona / customer	Persona is specific in behavior, frustrations, daily routine, and channels; backed by quotes; clear about who is not this customer.	Persona is specific in 2–3 of (behavior, frustration, routine, channel).	Persona is mostly demographic; behavior implied.	Customer described as a category ("kids") with no specifics.
Problem statement	Problem statement uses the [Customer] struggles with [problem] when [context], because [cause] format with all four parts grounded in evidence.	Problem statement names customer + problem; context and cause partial.	Problem statement is general or one-sided.	No problem statement, or it conflicts with the evidence.
Bias acknowledgment	Names 2+ ways the research could be biased or incomplete (sample size, leading questions, who was asked); proposes how to check.	Names 1 bias or limitation.	Mentions concerns about generalizability vaguely.	Treats research as definitive without caveats.
From evidence to action	Identifies at least 2 specific changes to product, message, or pricing driven by customer evidence; reasoning explicit.	Identifies 1 change driven by evidence.	Conclusions are general ("we should improve") without specifics.	No connection between evidence and decisions.

Scale notes by grade band:

- **Grades 4–6:** Use first 3 criteria only. "Quality of evidence" at this band means 1–2 customer interviews or surveys.
- **Grade 7–8:** Use all 5 criteria.
- **Grades 9–12:** Use all 5 with higher bar — 5+ interviews, formal coding, segmentation. At Grade 11–12, "From evidence to action" includes an explicit pivot or kill decision when warranted.

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Rubric 5 — Reflection Writing Rubric

For: end-of-unit memos, Capstone Journal portfolio grades, Cash-video response prompts, year-end synthesis writing.

Criterion	4 — Exemplary	3 — Proficient	2 — Developing	1 — Beginning
Specificity of self-observation	Cites at least 2 specific moments, decisions, or pieces of evidence; avoids generalities; names what was surprising or hard.	Cites 1 specific moment or decision.	Generalities dominate ("I learned a lot"); few specifics.	No specific reference to actual experience.
Evidence of revised thinking	Names at least 1 belief or assumption that changed during the unit/year, with the evidence that drove the change.	Names a change in thinking; evidence is implied or partial.	Acknowledges learning happened without naming what changed.	No evidence of thinking changing.
Honest naming of difficulty	Names something hard, confusing, or unresolved without minimizing or performing struggle.	Names a difficulty; some performance or minimization.	Mentions difficulty in passing without engagement.	Reflection avoids difficulty entirely.
Forward-looking specificity	Names at least 1 specific next step or question with the level of detail a reader could check on.	Names a next step in general terms.	Closes with platitudes ("I'll keep trying").	No forward-looking content, or generic optimism only.
Voice and ownership	Reflection sounds like the student's actual voice; first-person, specific to their experience; not formula-filled.	Sounds like the student; some formulaic phrasing.	Sounds like a generic student response; little ownership.	Sounds copy-pasted from elsewhere or written for the rubric.

Scale notes by grade band:

- **Grades 3–5:** Use first 3 criteria only. Acceptable form is 3–5 sentences.
- **Grades 6–8:** Use all 5 criteria. Acceptable form is 1 paragraph (8–12 sentences).
- **Grades 9–12:** Use all 5 with higher bar. Acceptable form is 1 page; Grade 12 reflection writing should connect this year's experience to a longer arc (their next 1–2 years' plan).

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Notes on rubric use

- **Grade-level adapters above are guides, not rules.** A skilled teacher may use a Grade 12 rubric on an unusually strong Grade 10 student or simplify down for a struggling group. Anchor papers help.
- **Rubrics are for student use, too.** Sharing rubrics before the assignment (and walking through one anchor paper) is one of the highest-leverage instructional moves available. Students who know the rubric outperform students who guess.
- **Don't grade neatness.** None of these rubrics include neatness or length unless they're part of the criterion (e.g., "concise" in pitch). Avoid penalizing for spelling unless the assignment is about writing.
- **Calibrate every cycle.** When a new teacher joins or a new grade level is added, score 3 anchor papers together before scoring independently.
- **Allow rubric translation.** ELL students benefit from a translated rubric, available in their home language, and a glossary of rubric terms (specificity, evidence, justification). Provided in the program assets.

One promise.

Assessment that changes what the student does next - not just what the gradebook records.

Cash to Company is built so a curriculum coordinator, a foundation officer, a parent, or a teacher can pick up any one of these strategic references and meet the program at full strength on the first page.

No promise of wealth. No probing of family finances. No partisan content. One question, asked patiently for thirteen years: which people, and how do you know?

For educational and operational use. This document is informational and does not constitute financial, legal, or tax advice. Standards alignment is cited per the Cash to Company Standards Alignment Map (Jump$tart, CEE, CCSS, C3, CASEL, NGSS-ETS).